Why Sexual Violence Persists

GS I

- Sexist attitudes and **gender stereotypes** can make disrespect towards women seem normal. When jokes about rape, sexualisation of women and disregard for consent become common, people may fail to recognise or challenge behaviour that can lead to sexual violence.
- People who know about sexual abuse may remain silent because of friendship, loyalty, fear or **social pressure**. Such silence protects offenders rather than victims and makes it easier for serious wrongdoing to continue without immediate intervention.
- Rules have little effect when institutions do not enforce them properly. Weak investigations, inadequate punishment or reluctance to confront offenders can create a **sense of impunity**, where people believe they may escape serious consequences for their actions.
- When society remains silent and institutions respond weakly, survivors may suffer greater consequences than offenders. This imbalance can discourage **accountability** and allows the conditions that enable sexual violence to continue even when formal rules exist.

Rules alone cannot prevent sexual violence. They work only when society challenges harmful attitudes, people speak against abuse and institutions hold offenders accountable.

Gaza Peace Deadlock

GS II

- Israel and Hamas disagree over the basic conditions for peace. Israel wants Hamas to give up its weapons before reconstruction moves forward, while Hamas wants Israeli forces to withdraw before disarming. This disagreement keeps the **peace process** stuck.
- Gaza also needs **massive reconstruction** after years of destruction, displacement and shortages. But rebuilding cannot move forward easily while fighting continues and the two sides disagree over security and control of the territory.
- The conflict has also become connected with wider tensions in West Asia, including confrontation involving Iran, Lebanon and Syria. These **regional conflicts** make the Gaza issue harder to isolate and resolve through negotiations alone.
- Politics in Israel and the role of the United States also influence what happens next. Changes in public opinion, political leadership and **American pressure** can affect whether the conflict continues militarily or moves towards a negotiated settlement.

Peace in Gaza requires more than stopping the fighting. Disarmament, withdrawal, reconstruction, regional tensions and political decisions must all be addressed for a lasting settlement.

India's Leprosy Challenge

GS II

- A low national prevalence created the impression that leprosy was largely under control, but transmission continued in several areas. When **specialised surveillance** was merged with the general health system, detecting and tracking remaining cases became more difficult.
- Leprosy is also unevenly distributed across India. Some States and districts continue to carry a much higher disease burden, and cases among children show that **fresh transmission** is still occurring within communities.
- Late diagnosis allows the disease to cause greater harm and makes control more difficult. **Social stigma** can discourage people from seeking treatment, while limited knowledge among some healthcare workers can lead to leprosy being missed or mistaken for other skin conditions.
- India therefore needs to focus on stopping transmission rather than relying mainly on falling prevalence figures. Strong surveillance, **early detection**, treatment of patients and their contacts, and targeted action in high-burden areas are necessary to interrupt the spread.

Leprosy control cannot be measured only by fewer registered cases. India must find infections early, reduce stigma and focus its efforts where transmission continues.

Understanding the Brain with Light

GS III

- Brain functions depend on nerve cells communicating through **electrical signals**, but identifying which cells control a particular memory, emotion or behaviour is difficult. Optogenetics gives researchers a way to study selected nerve cells more precisely.
- Optogenetics uses special proteins that respond to light. Scientists introduce genes for these **light-sensitive proteins** into selected nerve cells, allowing those cells to be switched on using carefully controlled pulses of light.
- By activating particular nerve cells and observing what changes, researchers can identify the **neural circuits** linked to specific memories, emotions, behaviours and bodily functions. This helps them understand how different parts of the brain work together.
- This understanding can support research into neurological and psychiatric disorders and may contribute to new treatments, including attempts to restore sight. The larger challenge is ensuring that advances from scientific research eventually become **accessible healthcare benefits**.

Optogenetics allows scientists to control selected nerve cells with light, helping reveal how brain circuits work and opening new possibilities for understanding and treating disease.